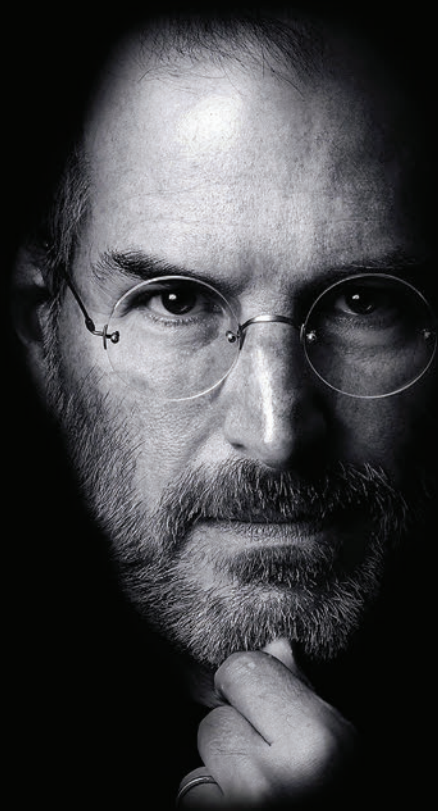


A visionary move

How **Steve Jobs** killed the keyboard and changed smartphones forever

By **Madhav Banka**



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Before the launch of the iPhone in 2007, the smartphone market was dominated by all the Nokias, the BlackBerrys, and the Motorolas. All the devices made by these companies were very popular in the market, and they had something in common, which was the presence of a physical keyboard.

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Back in 2007, at the launch of the original iPhone, Steve Jobs said, “Every once in a while, a revolutionary product comes along that changes everything.” And well, safe to say the iPhone really changed the smartphone market, forever.

Before Jobs set foot on the Macworld Expo back in the day, all the phones at the time followed a rather simple design. There was a little screen at the front, along with the physical keyboard, taking up most of the space. While this was the industry standard back in the day, it really limited what innovations could be made.

But Apple being Apple, did not want to do the same thing that every other company at the time was doing. Instead, they did something out of the box, playing a very big gamble, by completely ditching the physical keyboard. A decision that was laughed at first by many, but eventually, something that changed the smartphone game forever.

Let’s take a detailed look at how Steve Jobs’ boldest move of killing the physical keyboard changed smartphones forever!

The “glass slab” smartphone gamble

The concept of a phone launching without a physical keyboard was not something that the world expected to

see in 2007. Apple knew it and saw it as a big gamble; that is why they kept the iPhone launch a secret. While smartphones are leaked months before launch these days, that was not the case with the original iPhone.

Only a handful of Apple’s employees were able to interact with the prototype of the original iPhone before its launch. Because the company had put a strict NDA policy ensuring no details of the phone leaked outside.

After months of anticipation, the Macworld Expo 2007 Stage was all set for Steve Jobs to finally reveal to the world the iPhone. The room full of Journalists and Media personnel was simply shocked to see a phone without a keyboard. With a single slide at the launch event, Jobs didn’t just introduce a new product; he declared war on every company using physical buttons. He proposed the idea of a “giant screen” that could be anything that the user wants!

The problem that Jobs proposed with physical keyboards was that they were fixed hardware. Whenever something new is planned, months after the release of the phone, he found that it was not possible to change the physical hardware.

And that’s the reason he wanted the world to shift to software, because it would be possible for them to change the design, even if something new is planned later on.